MAJOR ONLINE PLAYERS

From fantasy cricket to online ludo, skill-based games with the chance to win real money are attracting millions of users to multiple digital platforms daily

DREAM11
2008
100 mn+
Fantasy sports

ZUPEE
2018
50 mn+
Ludo, trump cards

RUMMY CIRCLE
2009
50 mn+
Online rummy

APP
Year of launch
Total downloads*
Game type

**from Google Play*

MY11 CIRCLE
2019
50 mn+
Fantasy sports

RUSH
2021
50 mn+
Card/board games, fantasy sports

WINZO
2018
10 mn+
Card/board games, fantasy sports, etc.

MOBILE PREMIER LEAGUE
2018
10 mn+
Ludo, rummy, fantasy cricket, etc.

MPL

THE BIG BETTING BUSTS

Offshore betting platforms thrive in the grey areas, often masquerading as skill-based games. Here are a few that have landed squarely in the ED's crosshairs

FIEWIN
Crackdown: *Sept. 2024*
- Lured users with promises of high returns on playing games
- Had alleged links to Chinese operators
- Laundered Rs 400 cr. via mule accounts/ crypto wallets

PARIMATCH
Crackdown: *Dec. 2023*
- A sports betting firm based in Cyprus
- Expanded its operations in India in 2021
- Accused of tax evasion, money laundering and surrogate ads

MAHADEV
Crackdown: *Nov. 2023*
- Offered illegal gambling on poker, cricket etc.
- Had Indian promoters based in the UAE
- The ED exposed an alleged Rs 40,000 cr. money laundering operation linked to it

(ED) seized Rs 17.82 crore in cash and over Rs 22 crore in Bitcoin from a platform called E-nuggets, allegedly operated by Chinese nationals. According to Ananay Jain, director at risk advisory firm Grant Thornton Bharat, foreign-controlled apps, especially those from China, raise national security concerns due to potential ties with surveillance networks and data harvesting.

The avenue is proving a godsend for other devilish deeds as well. "As online gaming and betting platforms proliferate in India, so do the risks of financial fraud, data theft and phishing scams," says Jain. In a 2022 CERT-In report, online financial frauds linked to gaming platforms were found to have surged by 55 per cent.

Rohit Sharma, a research fellow at the Union ministry of defence's think-tank MP-IDSA, points to the 2024 Fiewin case—a gaming app run by Chinese operators that laundered nearly Rs 400 crore from Indian users—as a wake-up call. "The app used false promises of high returns to deceive users," says Sharma. The ED's probe into Fiewin revealed a web of international transactions routed through 'mule' accounts and cryptocurrency wallets—making detection and enforcement exceedingly difficult.

The jurisdictional grey zone these platforms operate in exacerbates the problem. Many are registered in tax havens like Malta, Cyprus and Curacao, well out of the reach of Indian regulators. They regularly violate multiple Indian laws, including the Foreign Exchange Management Act, Payment and Settlement Systems Act, Information Technology Act, and Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The very foundation of what counts as legal or illegal gaming remains blurred, says Kriti Singh, associate director and programme manager (online gaming) at The Dialogue, a tech policy think-tank. "Despite some legal clarity, regulatory ambiguity has created an environment where offshore